Mozart’s Fortieth Symphony

A Deep Dive into a Masterpiece

Please, introduce yourselves!

- Your name and pronouns
- Your prior experiences with music
  - as a listener
  - a performer





About Me

- Historical musicologist
  - It’s like art history but for music history
  - Ph.D., University of Minnesota
- Teaching:
  - LaSalle University
  - Temple University
  - Delaware Valley University
- Not a performer
  - Grew up studying violin and viola

Course Web Site



PowerPoint PDFs



Recommended recordings (including links)



Glossary of musical terms



Notes on notation

Goals of the class

- Help you to become better listeners
- Learn why this music matters
  - Go beyond personal enjoyment
- Learn to think about music historically
  - In the context of its composition
  - As it has been heard through the centuries



Why Mozart's 40th Symphony?

- Probably Mozart's most popular symphony
- It's just a very good piece of music!
- Follows some of the most important conventions for instrumental music of the "Long Nineteenth Century" (approx. 1789 to 1914)
  - Symphony
  - Sonata



Three Important Conventions

- What?
  - Symphony
  - Sonata
  - Minuet
- When?
  - The “Long Nineteenth Century” (about 1789 to 1914)



Who was Mozart?

- Born, Salzburg, 1756
- Toured Europe with father and sister as child prodigy
- 1773-1777, musician in Salzburg court of Bishop Colloredo
- 1777, becomes a freelancer
- 1781, moves to Vienna

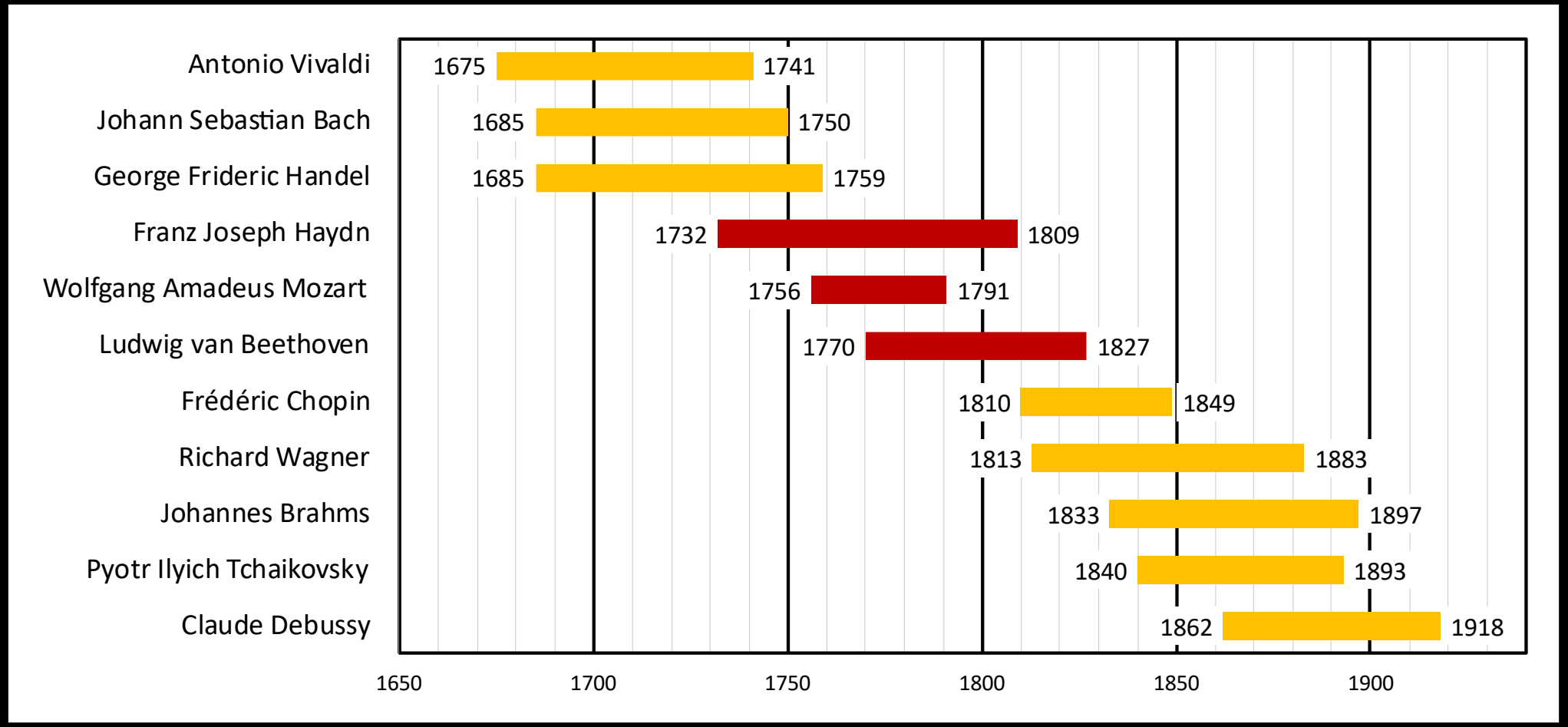


Mozart's Death

- December 5, 1791
- The myth: murdered by Antonio Salieri
- The reality: likely victim of an epidemic
- Buried in an unmarked grave
  - *Not* a suffering artist
  - Was very bad with money

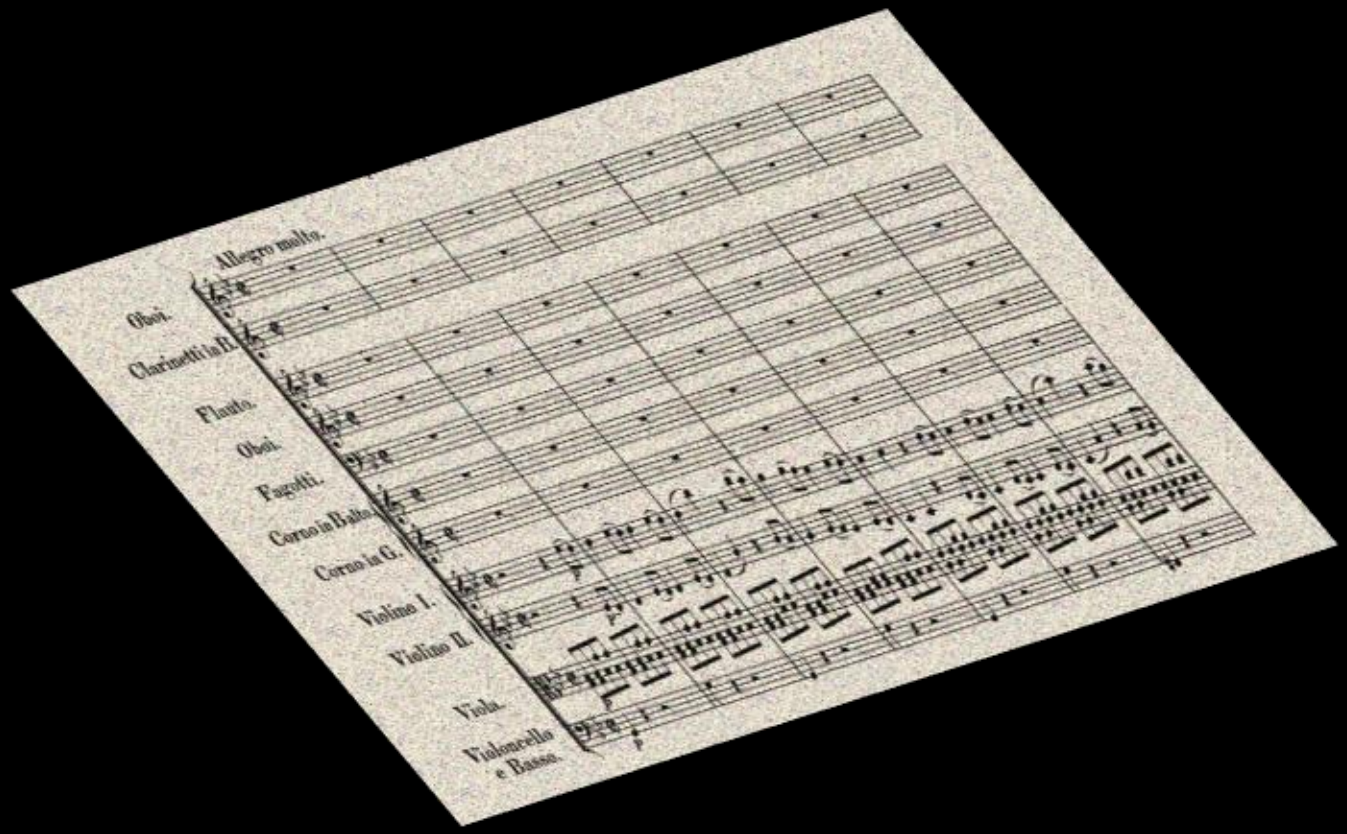


Mozart's Times



The Composition of the Symphony

- Summer of 1788: completed by 25 July
- Two versions:
  - No clarinets
  - Adds clarinets
- First performance?
  - Unknown!



Mozart's Significance: Viennese Classicism

- Three leading representatives of Viennese classicism
  - Franz Josef Haydn (1733-1809)
  - Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart (1756-1791)
  - Ludwig van Beethoven (1770-1827)

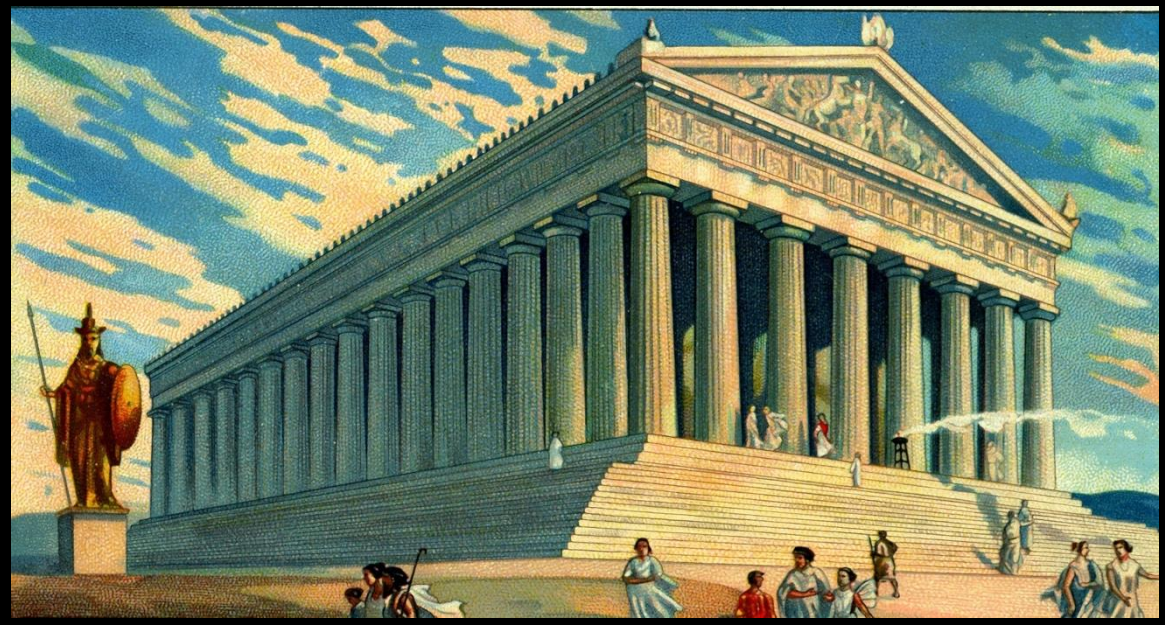






“Classicisms”

- “Classic:” model that transcends its own time
- The first classicism: ancient Greece
- “Modern” classicisms
  - Weimar literary classicism
    - Johann Wolfgang von Goethe (1749-1832)
    - Friedrich Schiller (1759-1805)
  - Viennese musical classicism
- Composing for the ages?
  - Sometimes, but usually not before Beethoven
  - Composers seldom had such independence before nineteenth century



Some Music!

- First movement: exposition (about 2 minutes
- Conductor: Andris Nelsons
- Orchestra: Gewandhausorchester Leipzig
- Recorded 2018

